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Edited by Rajesh Raj S. N. and Komol Singha

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THE ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOK OF POST-REFORM INDIAN ECONOMY

This handbook presents a comprehensive study of the post-reform Indian economy, three decades after the economic liberalization started in the early 1990s.

It studies the broad range of changes that were introduced in the reforms era, assessing their impact on sectors like manufacturing, agriculture, banking and finance, among others. It also assesses the performance of these sectors amid globalization and the socio-economic shifts in the country. The volume evaluates the contribution of the reforms to social transformation, social inclusion, sustainability and human development, and deliberates on the gains, blind spots and limitations. With contributions from scholars across the country, case studies and comparative analyses that draw on data analysis, econometric evidence and historical sensibility, this is an authoritative volume on the reforms of the 1990s and their impact on the Indian economy and people.

Topical and the first of its kind, the book will be a useful resource for scholars and researchers of economics, development studies, political economy, management studies, public policy and political studies.

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**Rajesh Raj S. N. dedicates this book to
Amma, Indira, Tanya**



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PREFACE

India launched its market-oriented reforms in 1991. Recognizing the importance of international competitiveness in an increasingly interdependent and globalizing world economy, the country's economic reforms specifically targeted the largely restrictive trade and industrial policies. They included a gradual reduction of industrial licensing, removal/reduction of import duties for almost all manufactured intermediate and capital goods, tariff reduction and relaxation of rules for foreign investment, etc. The post-reforms period also witnessed a series of fiscal, monetary and financial sector reforms. The fundamental objective of these measures was to bring about a rapid and sustained improvement in the quality of life of the people of India through sustained growth in income and productive employment.

These structural reforms in the Indian economy are now almost 30 years old. But scholars and analysts have offered divergent views on the impact of these reforms on various sectors of the economy. While some economists and analysts have highlighted the significant gains in terms of acceleration of growth, trade and market expansion, and industrial competitiveness, there are many critics who vehemently argued that the reforms have not produced expected outcomes in economic and social indicators. These sceptics point to the surging inequality in income, low rate of employment generation and sluggishness in agriculture to question the much-touted success of the 1991 reforms. They aver that it is no secret that the country witnessed its slowest social improvement during this period and that, specifically, educational and health indicators grew at a substantially slower rate than before.

In this context, the Department of Economics, Sikkim University, Gangtok, organized a two-day national conference on 'India after a Quarter Century of Economic Reforms: The Benefits and Costs' from 5 to 6 October 2018. The seminar was sponsored by the Directorate of Economics, Statistics, Monitoring and Evaluation (DESM&E), Government of Sikkim, Sikkim, India. The conference brought together policy makers, academicians, researchers and leading social scientists within the country. The seminar through its papers deliberated on the transformation of the Indian economy in the past two-and-a-half decades of economic reforms and also discussed new ideas that can help India reduce poverty and inequality, and embark on the path of growth and sustainability in the next 25 years. This edited volume is an outcome of this seminar and comprises several papers presented at the conference, selected based on their relevance to the theme, critical approach and strength of their suggestions. The findings, as arrived at by different contributors in various chapters, highlight the critical issues related to the implemen-

Preface

tation of reforms and their impact on various sectors of the economy and further the debate on the theme. All the chapters included in this volume present new material based on current research and have been subjected to rigorous internal reading and external refereeing. We do hope that this will be useful to the academia, research scholars, undergraduate and postgraduate courses in the disciplines of economics, commerce, management, economics, geography, development studies and other social sciences.

We are thankful to all the contributors. We are grateful to Sikkim University for providing the infrastructure and other support for the workshop. We gratefully acknowledge the generous financial support from DESM&E, Government of Sikkim (GoS), without which it would not have been possible for us to organize the seminar. We are also thankful to the reviewers who reviewed the manuscript. We also thank Prabin Chauhan Chhetri for the excellent research assistance. Finally, we thank the editorial team at Routledge, without whose continuous support, this volume would not have seen the light of day.

Gangtok, India
4 January 2021

Rajesh Raj S. N.
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INTRODUCTION

Rajesh Raj S. N. and Komol Singha

India launched its market-oriented reforms in 1991. These reforms represented a clear departure from the strongly inward-looking trade policy regime followed in India until then. Recognising the importance of international competitiveness in an increasingly interdependent and globalising world economy, the economic reforms specifically targeted the largely restrictive trade and industrial policies. They included a gradual dismantling of industrial licensing, removal of import licensing for nearly all manufactured intermediate and capital goods, tariff reduction and relaxation of rules for foreign investment (Srinivasan, 2000). The period also witnessed a series of fiscal reforms and monetary and financial-sector reforms. While fiscal reforms strove to attain fiscal discipline, the monetary reforms mainly aimed to eliminate interest rate distortions and rationalise the structure of lending rates. The fundamental objective of these measures was to bring about rapid and sustained improvement in the quality of life of the people of India through sustained growth in income and productive employment.

These reforms are now almost 30 years old. But views on the impact of these structural reforms on various sectors of the Indian economy are divergent. While some economists and analysts highlight the significant gains in terms of acceleration of growth, trade and market expansion and industrial competitiveness (Panagariya, 2008; Ahluwalia, 2019), among other things, there are others who vehemently argue that the reforms have not produced expected outcomes in social indicators. These sceptics point to the surging inequality in income, low rate of employment generation and sluggishness in agriculture to question the much-touted success of the 1991 reforms (Jha, 2004; Himanshu, 2019; Kannan and Raveendran, 2009; Thomas, 2012; Balakrishnan, 2000). These critics aver that it is no secret that the country witnessed its slowest social improvement during this period, and that, specifically, educational and health indicators grew at a substantially slower rate than earlier (Ray, 2008). The recent slump in growth and a greater tendency towards protectionism have further strengthened their arguments. Despite these conflicting views, a serious deliberation on the benefits and costs of reforms has not happened. Time is now far riper than ever to discuss and deliberate on the gains, limits and limitations of these reforms.

Some of the important policy events that unfolded with the formation of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government at the Centre since 2014 are also likely to influence, adversely or positively, the development of various sectors of Indian economy. They include the end of Inspector Raj for small and medium firms; 23 years after India got rid of Licence Raj

in 1991, welfare schemes targeted mainly at women (Ujjwala scheme that began in 2016) and several other policies, including demonetisation, GST system, programmes to enhance banking to the poor (Pradhan Mantri Jan-Dhan Yojana), Direct Benefit Transfer scheme and so on. In addition, some of the initiatives undertaken during the NDA regime that are worth mentioning include Make in India, scrapping of Foreign Investment Promotion Board, Smart Cities mission and The Arbitration and Conciliation (Amendment) Act. An array of similar reforms were effected in the agricultural sector too and includes Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (PKVY), Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi Yojana (PMKSNY), Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY) and Pradhan Mantri Sinchai Yojana, among others.¹ Some amendments that were observed in the financial sector include Finance Act (2016) and The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code.²

Although the direct impact of these reforms is hard to capture, the large-scale implications of such amendments cannot be overlooked. For instance, bilateral ties have a direct bearing on Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) flows (both inward and outward) and trade. Similarly, various schemes initiated in the agriculture sector might explain the recent trends in agricultural production and productivity. While some of the nuances of such initiatives taken by the NDA government in recent years have been highlighted in the book, there is less focus on the implications of these initiatives on various macro issues such as poverty, income distribution, gender welfare, GDP and so on. The lack of adequate attention to the recent initiatives mainly emanates from the fact that these new initiatives or schemes started by the NDA government is fairly new and, therefore, its impact may not be clearly evident in such a short time period. However, the book has largely tried to provide a comprehensive understanding of the Indian economy in the post-reform period with statistical evidence, as and when available.

This handbook is conceived to fill this obvious gap in the literature and aims to provide a perspective on how the new policies adopted since 1991 have changed the economic landscape of India. Besides providing an easily accessible summary of a broad range of changes that took place in the reforms era, the chapters included in the volume also evaluate the contribution of these policies to social inclusion and social transformation through the lens of land reforms, food security, poverty reduction and overall human development. The chapters also discuss new ideas that can help India reduce poverty and inequality and embark on the path of growth and sustainability. Due care was taken during the selection of the chapters to ensure that the volume does not seem like a random collection of essays. Most of the contributions were drawn from scholars who are experts in their respective areas. In doing so, we were gently dirigiste in getting contributions that could be grouped under six main topics: 'Agrarian Reforms and Agriculture', 'Trade and Manufacturing', 'Financial Sector Developments', 'FDI, R&D and Innovation', 'Social Sector in India' and 'Sectoral and Regional Issues'. We are fairly successful in obtaining chapters that offer a serious and critical discussion on each of the above topics.

The first section consisting of five chapters (Chapter 1–5) is on the theme 'Agrarian Reforms and Agriculture'. While economic growth has certainly picked up in the post-reforms period, not every sector has been a part of the growth story. The agricultural sector is one such laggard. In their chapter, Thomas and Satheesha probe this issue and examine the trends in growth of incomes and output in Indian agriculture. Along with examining the performance at the state level, the study also investigates how the state-level differences in growth influence the pattern of growth in rural labour markets. They find that the agricultural growth in India has not been consistent and marked by large temporal and spatial variations. The agricultural incomes in India grew faster during the 1980s but registered a sharp decline during the 1990s and the first half of the 2000s. The sector then witnessed a revival during the period 2004–2005 to 2011–2012, only to report a fall again after 2011–2012. However, the growth performance varied across the

Indian states. According to the study, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Haryana continue to lead the way with respect to food grain production though the growth of food grain production seems to have attained some degree of saturation in these states. The study also finds significant shift of the labour force away from the agriculture since the mid-2000s, and the major reasons for this were the emergence of employment opportunities in rural construction, cropping pattern and emergence of employment opportunities in the non-agricultural sectors.

The next chapter by Anand chimes in well with the first chapter. He undertakes a careful investigation of the sources of agricultural growth and the distributional aspect of this growth process in the reforms period. In particular, the study traces the sources that contributed to the recovery of agricultural growth post-2004–2005 period. Anand attributes the growth revival to favourable terms of trade, farm diversification, increase in public spending and intensified input use as indicated by a rise in the sale of tractors, fertiliser consumption and credit availability. The rise in output price and yield too contributed to the recovery of agricultural growth in the mid-2000 period. A related question explored by the chapter is the distributional outcomes of agrarian changes prompted by the growth revival. Based on evidence collected from National Sample Survey Office (NSSO) surveys, Anand maintains that the agricultural growth in India has not only been promoting inequality, but it has also been immiserising for the bottom 20 percent of farmer households. He contends that the fruits of agricultural growth have largely been cornered by large land holders. Considering the economic conditions of small holders and their reliance on oppressive sources of credit, the author envisages further worsening of India's agrarian crisis and calls for greater government intervention to provide reprieve to the peasantry who are in distress notwithstanding the high growth.

Redistributive land reform and agrarian reforms since the introduction of new economic policies gradually changed the agrarian structure and the associated class relations in India. Focusing on the issue of 'redistributive land reform' in the context of neoliberal globalisation, Rumba in his chapter argues that agrarian structure has witnessed a substantial change during the post-reforms period. One such change noticed by the author is the movement of landowning households from the farm sector to the non-farm sector. This has led to the emergence of larger proportion of landowning but non-cultivating households who otherwise used to be the permanent supplier of land in the land lease market. This coupled with declining job opportunities in the agricultural sector has forced the labour supplying households to enter the tenancy market despite the steep land rental price. Along with the increase in the inequities in access to land, the chapter by Rumba also highlights the rise of the 'land hunger class', who are willing to cultivate and pay high rent in the land lease market, in the post-reform period. The chapter emphasises that the agrarian structure in neoliberal India comprises two types of households: who are eager to cultivate land but are landless or own small plots of land and the other who owns land but does not want to do any cultivation.

In the next chapter, Manjunath investigates the nexus between infrastructure and agriculture in rural areas in the context of the Indian state of Karnataka. The emphasis is on the role of economic and institutional infrastructure and human capital on agricultural growth. Using a composite index of quality of rural infrastructure, the study examines the availability, quality and utilisation of infrastructure in rural areas and its subsequent effect on agricultural income. Based on the field survey data collected from 20 districts, his study suggests substantial inter-district disparity in access to and quality of rural infrastructure in the state. He then establishes that such disparities in infrastructural quality do explain the inter-district differences in agricultural income. The finding of positive nexus between infrastructural quality and agricultural growth, according to him, reveals how important it is to enhance the quality of infrastructure in

rural areas. The study emphasises that rather than focusing on mere provision of infrastructure with regard to quantity, the stress should be on efficiency and quality of such provisions.

Environmental sustainability is the area where the progress is less evident. In fact, all important indicators relating to environmental sustainability demonstrate steady deterioration. Though its relevance is increasingly recognised in policy-making circles, there exists very limited research examining whether the economic reforms have succeeded in attaining environmental sustainability. The last chapter in this section attempts to fill this void in the literature. The authors analyse the trends in the macro- and micro-level economic indicators that measure the well-being of the people and assess the impact of these indicators on the environment. They agree that India has witnessed significant economic achievements in the post-reforms period. Along with the increase in gross domestic product, there has been substantial improvement in social indicators too. However, this demographic and economic growth has put considerable pressure on agriculture, forests, subsoils and air and water resources leading to resource degradation. They establish that pollution levels and environmental degradation have increased due to increased consumption levels and extraction of resources. According to the authors, 'Increase in the corporations, changes in consumption patterns with higher environmental foot prints, along with the extraction of resources with little regard for sustainability of the resources has put India's environmental and social sustainability at stake'. They argue that it is high time for India to move to a new phase of environmentally inclusive reforms. Which means the focus must be on enhancing human capabilities and minimising the impact on environment through sustainable use of natural resources, proper waste management and by reducing environmental pollution.

The chapters in the second section are concerned with 'Trade and Manufacturing'. The section has six chapters and most of these chapters examine how these reforms, especially the substantial liberalisation in trade policy, impacted the performance of the manufacturing sector. These chapters are expected to spur wider discussion on whether the manufacturing sector has performed to its potential in the past two-and-a-half decades of economic reforms or, as argued in one of the chapters, whether we need to re-invent industrial policy keeping in view the long-term national goals.

Nagaraj examines India's industrial performance in the aftermath of 1991 reforms and attempts to draw lessons from this performance for the future. He stresses that the liberal economic reforms carried out over the last quarter century has not benefitted the manufacturing sector, despite faster economic growth and output diversification. In his view, India failed to catch up with its Asian peers to cement its reputation as a successful industrialised nation with rising manufactured exports even after a quarter century of the market-oriented reforms. What explains the underperformance of India's industrial sector? He dismisses the contention of the protagonists of reforms that incomplete reforms have hobbled industrialisation in India. Debunking the claim of labour market rigidity as a reason for industrial stagnation, he states that recent experiences suggest that 'hire and fire' policy effectively rules the organised labour market today. Evidence on the employment of non-permanent workers in large numbers by large enterprises points to the fact that the seemingly rigid laws do not apply to a growing segment of organised workers. Rather his reasons for industrial stagnation post reforms lie in 'structuralist economic view of India's long-term constraint as one with low agriculture productivity (compared to global average), poor public infrastructure and extreme energy import dependence'. While suggesting the solutions to step up industrialisation, he emphasises the importance of extensive state intervention to accelerate domestic savings and public investment. He also stresses the need to locate industries and products in which imports are succeeding on account of easy credit and those which require productivity improvement.

Goldar analyses the reasons for a slide in labour incomes in India's organised manufacturing sector since the 1990s. In his chapter, he is particularly interested in investigating the role of India's trade reforms on labour income share in organised manufacturing. The analysis is carried out for the period 1990–1991 to 2014–15, a period encompassing approximately a quarter century of economic reforms in India, using industry and plant-level panel data. His study finds a clear downward trend in labour income share in the post-reform period till 2007–08, and an upward trend thereafter. The finding of downward trend in labour income share during 1990–91 to 2007–08 and the post-2007 trend reversal are also visible among two-digit industries. While looking at the factors that contributed to the decline in labour income share, the econometric analysis points to the significant role played by trade reforms. The study finds that import liberalisation contributed heavily to the fall in labour income share which led to the widening of the gap between growth of labour productivity and growth of real product wages. Apart from trade reforms, increase in capital intensity and increase in total factor productivity also contributed to the declining share of labour income. Finally, the chapter also tries to locate the factors that explain the trend reversal in labour income share in manufacturing after 2007. The analysis reveals that the prime explanation lies in the significant rise in the growth rate of real wages in agriculture. Goldar argues that faster growth in real wages in agriculture drove up the wages in manufacturing which led to an increase in labour income share.

The next chapter in this section focuses on the export competitiveness of Indian manufacturing sector since the onset of trade liberalisation reforms in the early 1990s. The chapter by Rijesh noted a sharp decline in the levels of trade protection in the post-reform era. In particular, the peak tariff on manufactures has declined from 400 percent in the early 1990s to less than 10 percent in the recent period. At the same time, there has been a significant improvement in goods trade in the post-liberalisation period; both exports and imports have registered double-digit growth rates. Along with strong trade performance, the study also finds a noticeable shift in trade composition towards technology-intensive products like machinery and chemical sectors. While exploring the link between trade liberalisation and export competitiveness, the study concludes that trade liberalisation policy alone is not sufficient to achieve higher export competitiveness in the international market. Instead, it is important to focus more on investing in technology and knowledge-based assets to reduce production cost and improve the quality of the exported products. To achieve this, 'creating a well-functioning institutional apparatus, improved physical infrastructure, and environment for the development of innovative production capabilities' are in order.

One cannot deny the important role of services sector in influencing manufacturing growth. Given that manufacturing performance depends critically on the state of service inputs, Mausumi Kar argues that services sector might have played a key role in the success of the Indian manufacturing sector, especially in the post-reforms period. Kar maintains that the reforms of the 1990s have greatly transformed the services sectors, thereby allowing foreign and domestic competition with greatly improved regulation. She goes on to state that such improvements have enhanced firms' ability to invest in new business opportunities and better production technology as well as to exploit economies of scale. In her chapter, she probes whether such rapid improvements in service-led activities had a positive spillover effect on its manufacturing counterpart. Her econometric investigation at the state-level reveals that all round expansion of services trade may not necessarily augment productivity performance of manufacturing sector. On the contrary, the manufacturing sector is more likely to experience lower labour productivity and income, if there is too large an expansion of services trade. She therefore contends that limitless growth of services trade is unlikely to be a promising strategy for a country like India which advances inclusive growth as its long-run developmental goal.

The liberalisation of trade regime in the 1990s has led to substantial increase in the inflow of FDI to India. This has led to a huge surge in studies looking at the role of FDI spillover effects on productivity and export performance of Indian manufacturing firms. The next chapter by Mondal contributes to this burgeoning literature by examining the role of FDI spillover effects on export performance. As a departure from the existing studies, her study classifies firms into different categories based on their technology intensity to find out if the role of FDI spillover effects on export performance varies across the technology category sectors. Following the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) definition, the study classifies the firms into four technology intensity sectors, namely, High Technology (HT), Medium High Technology (MHT), Medium Low Technology (MLT) and Low Technology (LT) sectors. Her empirical analysis based on data for 6,000 Indian firms suggests limited role for FDI spillovers in influencing export decision or export activity of the Indian firms. The study, on the other hand, finds that export performance of firms crucially hinges on in-house R&D activity and technology import. Mondal, therefore, stresses the need for encouraging more in-house R&D activities and skill enhancement through proper training.

Over the years, there has been an increased attention towards easing the procedural hassles in doing business and conducting cross-border trade over time. The last chapter in this section by Nalin Kumar discusses the effect of such reform measures on India's agri-food trade sector. He then examines the distractive effects of reforms induced by the ease of doing business. His analysis is based on two sectors, namely, marine products and spices export sectors, the sectors where non-tariff barriers are highly prevalent and the ones which face severe competition from leading exporters. His analysis reveals that the lack of co-evolution of institutions in implementing trade policy reforms resulted in a scenario in which reforms do not trickle down to a sector. On the one hand, continued trade policy reforms failed to tackle issues related to standards, non-tariff barriers and the burden of documentation for India's agri-food exports. On the other hand, the reforms induced by the ease of doing business distract the very basic institutional and infrastructural reforms the sector deserves.

The third section titled 'Financial Sector Developments' basically deals with the structural changes that have occurred in the Indian financial system in the post-reforms era. It reflects upon various dimensions of the Indian financial system such as resource sharing, trends in inflation following the globalisation process, firm portfolio and financing behaviour of non-financial corporations (NFCs) and shadow banking, among others. While the first chapter in the section is descriptive in nature, the remaining three chapters employ econometric exercises to fulfil their objectives.

The first chapter in this section brings into light the issues involved with using the census population of 1971 as the criterion for sharing resources among Indian states. The authors argue that in order to have a fair and equitable resource sharing, a more recent population census must be chosen as the base. They vouch for the replacement of 1971 population estimate with the most recent population census, that is, 2011. In the process, they also question the fundamental idea of using population size as a resource-sharing criterion among Indian states and talk about designing an appropriate grant mechanism that can actually reward better performing states rather than penalise them by increasing their fiscal burden. In the next chapter, the authors explore yet another dimension of reforms that was undertaken in the early 1990s and examines the association between globalisation and rate of inflation in India. The use of the latest Reserve Bank of India (RBI) database from 1991–92 to 2018–19 adds significantly to the literature on this topic. The study reveals that there exists a unidirectional causality between globalisation and rate of inflation. Using trade openness and FDI inflow as the indicators of globalisation, they conclude that globalisation and money supply have a positive impact on inflation in India.

Sushant Kumar Singh in his chapter analyses the changes that the firm portfolio and financing behaviour of the NFCs have undergone in India in the post-reforms period, using firm-level data drawn from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) prowess database. He outlines the changing behaviour of NFCs and articulates the interrelations between financialisation and corporate decisions in the post-reform era. The study closely scrutinises the sector-wise consolidated annual financial statements of firms to identify the investment behaviour of Indian firms. The study finds that the process of financialisation is mainly taking place through expansion of the stock market and the derivative market. The study also finds sharp evidence of changes in investment behaviour of firms during this period. The firms are increasingly investing in financial assets and paying out huge chunk of their profits to financial agents. His analysis also points to a declining trend in the creation of new physical assets indicating a fall in the growth of real accumulation process and financial activities.

The last chapter by Dawa Sherpa resonates well with the previous chapter and provides an overview of financial system in India in general and shadow banks in particular. Like the previous chapter, this chapter too relies on the CMIE prowess database to depict the rise of shadow banks in Indian financial system in the post-reforms period with partial emphasis on gold loan. Basically, the study highlights the systemic risks shadow banks poses to the overall financial system in India. The study shows that although shadow financial institutions have become more interconnected with other parts of the financial system, in the process, they have also become more sophisticated in terms of their activities and risk-taking positions. Due to its excessive dependency on bank borrowings, a gold loan Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC) is vulnerable to funding shocks, liquidity shocks and its asset quality being deteriorated overtime. He therefore argues for increasing the regulation of the gold loan NBFCs and controlling their reliance on banks.

The fourth section deals with FDI, R&D and innovation. This section has three chapters. One of the prominent developments in the post-liberalisation years is the substantial rise in FDI. This surge in FDI in India is largely aided by relaxation of policies on investment, such as investment incentives, and the reduction or elimination of capital controls and other forms of barriers to investment. There is a very general agreement that FDI inflows aid the growth and development of the economies of host countries through employment generation, expansion of supply of goods and increased revenue generation through rise in exports. In addition, there can also be spillover effects associated with FDI originating from foreign companies, which can help in the provision of new skills and technologies for domestic producers. Have the benefits from the rise in FDI inflows trickled down? The chapters in this section attempt to provide an answer to this question.

A highly crucial aspect of external sector liberalisation is the proliferation of bilateral investment treaties between countries. These treaties safeguard the rights of investments of foreign firms through an array of investors' rights, and in most cases, allow the investors to take to legal course if the rights are violated. It is argued that bilateral investment treaties boost the credibility of host countries and results in increased investment. The impact of such treaties on FDI has been the focus of many existing studies. Majority of these studies in the context of developing countries, however, have focused on the role of bilateral investment treaties on attracting FDI while its role on stimulating outward FDI has been barely studied in the literature. In his chapter, Kathuria concentrates on this aspect and studies the role of bilateral investment treaties on outward FDI from India. His study is based on the outward FDI data from India to 140 countries over the period 2007–2014. In terms of outward FDI stock, India is currently the 11th largest economy among all emerging markets, according to the study. The study also reports that signing and ratification of bilateral investment treaties was an important activity in

the post-liberalisation period. However, the analysis by Kathuria does not find any role for such treaties in influencing outward foreign direct investment (OFDI). His panel data analysis shows that outward FDI from India is not influenced by bilateral investment treaties. On the other hand, it is the economic growth, per capita income and size of the country that have induced outward FDI. Though aggregate OFDI may not have gone up with bilateral investment treaties, Kathuria believes that investor protection clause in such treaties may still have enhanced the effects of other types of investment policies.

The next chapter by Bishwanjit Singh examines the impact of foreign ownership and Intellectual property rights (IPR) protection on innovation activities. He writes that the market shares of Multinational companies (MNCs) witnessed a significant upsurge following the trade liberalisation of 1991 and patent policy changes thereafter. This is particularly more evident in the Indian pharmaceutical industry. He argues that the expansion of foreign ownership in Indian pharmaceutical firms is likely to augment R&D activities in these firms. His study for the period 1999 to 2014 using the annual census data of 552 firms investigates this possibility in the Indian pharmaceutical industry. The findings confirm this possibility and suggest that foreign ownership encourages domestic firms to undertake R&D activities. It is also found that the relationship is more robust among exporting firms. However, the study finds little evidence to support the role of patent policy changes on R&D activities.

In the last chapter in this section, Nidhi Singh traces the system building activities of molecular diagnostic industry in the aftermath of economic liberalisation programme initiated in the 1990s. By adopting a system framework and using both secondary and primary survey data, the study finds that trade liberalisation has mostly favoured the foreign firms while domestic players have hardly benefitted from the trade reforms. The study shows the heavy reliance on imports and equipment from abroad by the actors in this industry as direct implications of trade liberalisation policy regime initiated since the 1990s. Even the innovative capabilities in terms of production, technology and investment are found to be highly concentrated in the hands of few MNCs. On the other hand, the domestic industrial base has a nascent presence and the young start-up firms serve the bulk of indigenous product development that meets the severe health care problems of the wider society. According to the study, since the development of the industrial base has a transformative effect on the present healthcare diagnostic system, there is a need to address the system-based challenges and issues for developing a socially responsible molecular diagnostic industrial base in the country.

The fifth section of this compendium focuses on the broader theme 'Social Sector in India'. The five chapters in this section touch upon the basic dimensions of human development and reflect the current scenario with respect to health, nutrition and education in India. The first chapter in this section traces the nexus between agriculture and nutrition status in India. The next two chapters focus on the performance of public distribution system and compare the two conventional approaches, namely universal approach and targeted Public Distribution System (PDS) approach. The fourth chapter briefly highlights the silent withdrawal of government which has paved the way for the private players to flourish and further widen the inequality in the education sector. It emphasises on the role of government to address the issue. The last chapter deals with the methodological issues involved in calculating the Human Development Index.

Despite high economic growth, nutritional deficiencies have loomed darkly in the Indian health sector affecting infants, children, men and women in India. Scholars argue that progress in nutritional status have not been able to keep pace with the country's impressive success in hastening economic growth in last few decades. This forms the crux of Chapter 19 by Pandey where he investigates the relationship between agriculture and nutrition status in India. Here, he argues that one of the solutions to food and nutrition security lies in agricultural growth

as improved agriculture leading to better household food security can ensure adequate dietary intake and nutritional status. According to the study, malnutrition is present in most of the states of India. Besides the agrarian states of Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand and Madhya Pradesh, the study reports higher levels of malnutrition in high-income states of Maharashtra, Karnataka and Gujarat too, belying the general belief that high-income states tend to have low level of malnutrition. By employing an econometric analysis, the study further probes the link between agriculture and nutrition and gives credence to the significant role of agricultural performance in explaining the difference between levels of malnutrition across the states of India. The analysis also underscores the important role of agriculture diversification, household amenities and child-care practices on nutritional status. The findings from the study persuade the author to emphasise the need to increase farmers' income in order to address the issue of malnutrition.

Rising expenditure on non-food essentials has pushed poorer sections of the society into a nutritional trap. Shining a light on this issue, the next chapter by Anjana Thampi examines the state-level variations in nutrition and the role of PDS in mitigating any nutritional deficiency. To be precise, she compares the state-level variations in the incidence of hunger and undernutrition using Global Hunger Index and examines the nutritional impact of PDS in India. She highlights the extent to which PDS has been successful in bridging the nutritional gap among the poor population, especially in rural areas. The study finds that PDS has turned out to be a positive and successful step to tackle hunger and undernutrition situation in India.

Corroborating on the point that poorer section needs due attention, Marina Rai compares the efficiency of the two approaches (universal approach versus targeted approach) of PDS in India, with particular reference to two major states viz. West Bengal and Tamil Nadu. Using NSSO survey data, this study provides a succinct overview of the performance of PDS in these two states (one following the universal approach while the other following the targeted approach) in both rural as well as urban areas during the period 1993–94 to 2009–10. The study concludes that universal approach is more effective especially due to higher participation, lower targeting errors of excluding the needy and greater benefits to the poor which improve nutritional outcomes among the beneficiaries.

The chapter by Sengupta explores the interplay between two forces (public and private) in the education market in India and seeks to identify the determinants of private tuitions in India. Using NSSO data (42nd and 71st rounds), the chapter flags the issue of silent withdrawal by the government from the education sector (through reduced investment) which has paved the way for the private players to flourish and capitalise the sector. It is well-known that the probability of attending tuition is more for the privileged children (belonging to the higher income group and forward caste) than the underprivileged. Keeping this in mind, any backward step (here, withdrawal from the education market) taken by the government will further widen the gap between the haves and the have-nots. The study suggests that instead of carving out an escape plan and thereby reinforcing inequality in the society in terms of access to education, the government must take up a pro-active role and look for an alternative form of market in education which is exclusively based on 'ability to pay'.

The final chapter in this section brings to light new evidence in difference in the value of HDI that arises solely due to changes in methodology in calculating Human Development Index (HDI). Using 2010 as the focal point, the study shows that a shift from the old methodology (prior to 2010) to a new methodology (after 2010) has cost India's HDI progress by around one decade. Using deterministic regression model, the study shows that during 1990–2014, education index has contributed more in increasing HDI value than health index and income

index. The study also performs an out-sample forecasting and finds that India is expected to enter into High HDI (HHDI) by 2037 and Very High HDI (VHHDI) by 2048.

The last section in this compendium focuses on the theme ‘Sectoral and Regional Issues’. The four chapters in this section highlight some of the relevant issues at the sectoral and sub-national level that have received less attention in the existing scholarly literature. The North Eastern Region (NER) of India is considered as the vital cog in the Act East Policy. Therefore, it becomes extremely important to have a comprehensive understanding of the growth dynamics of the region and the first chapter exactly does that. Using secondary data between 1980 and 2010, the study analyses the state-wise and sector-wise performance of the NER and highlights the dominance of tertiary sector over primary and secondary sector in the region. In other words, the study finds that there is a constant rise in the share of tertiary sector and a fall in the share of primary sector during the period. The study further reveals that the tertiary sector is turning out to be the driving force for economic growth in the region in recent decades.

The next chapter deals with the structural transformation of the rural economy in the post-reform period in India. In this chapter, Dhara employs the Employment and Unemployment Survey data of the NSSO for the period 1990–2010 to examine whether growth in rural non-farm employment is ‘distress driven’ or ‘growth driven’. In other words, it analyses the determinants of rural non-farm employment in India by taking into account the push and pull factors operating behind rural occupational transformation. She examines this question separately for male and female workforce and finds clear gender-wise differences in factors influencing the employment transition. While the transition from agricultural to non-agricultural sectors for male workforce is driven by growth-related forces, such transitions are mostly distress-driven for female workers.

The next chapter studies the implications of oil price shocks on employment and wages of workers in the transport sector of India. In this study, Saibal Kar and Sweta Lahiri employ a general equilibrium model to address this issue. Using unit level data from three rounds of NSSO viz. 61st round (2003–04), 66th round (2009–10) and 68th round (2011–12), the study concludes that oil price rise is likely to affect the wages of the workers negatively which is mainly due to potential mobility of such workers from formal to informal sub-sectors within the transport sector. While higher educational qualification helps to raise the real wages, reforms in the labour market may increase wages of informal workers in the event of oil price shocks.

The final chapter in this theme tries to capture the gender element of trade expansion in the plantation sector in India. The study makes use of seven rounds of occupational wage survey of the plantation industry during 1958–2016 to locate the changing composition of the workforce based on gender differences across industries and occupations in the sector with a special focus on post-liberalisation period. The study lends strong support to the endogenous growth model and concludes that the impact of trade liberalisation on gender is highly sector specific and may further widen the gap between males and females, particularly in terms of equality and wages.

The chapters included in this handbook together constitute the largest single collection of evidence on the impact of reforms on the Indian economy and the people. The wide-angled vision, historical sensibility, data analysis and econometric evidence contained in these chapters offer a more nuanced and granular picture of economic liberalisation. In doing so, it also questions some adventurist narratives on the recent economic history of the country. The chapters in this collection ought to be of interest to students, teachers and researchers of Indian economy, particularly due to its comprehensive coverage on the impact of reforms on various aspects of the economy since the start. In our opinion, this collection provides a ‘one solution’ to many serious and contentious issues that have revolved around reforms in India.

Notes

- 1 All these schemes were within the ambit of the National Sustainable Agriculture Mission (NSAM) which basically aimed to boost agricultural production, increase farmer's income and provide safety nets to small and marginal farmers, thereby providing relief to the agriculture sector.
- 2 Similar initiatives were undertaken in other sectors too, which we do not discuss here.

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